



Cystic Fibrosis Carrier Screening

What you need to know about CF genetic testing

What is cystic fibrosis (CF)?

Cystic fibrosis (CF) is a disease that affects a person's long-term health and lifespan. It often causes problems with digestion and

breathing. In some cases, CF can be a mild disease. But in most people with CF, it poses a serious risk to a person's health. The average

lifespan of a person with CF is 37 years. Those with a milder form can live into their 50s.

What causes CF?

Cystic fibrosis is a genetic disorder caused by a gene that is passed from parent to child. It takes two genes—one from the mother and

one from the father—for a person to have CF. If a person has only one copy of a gene for CF, he or she is known as a carrier. Carriers

often do not know that they have a gene for CF. They usually do not have symptoms or may have only mild symptoms. If both parents are

carriers, each of their children has a 25% chance of having the disorder. Put another way, this couple has a 1-in-4 chance of having a

child with CF.

What are the symptoms of CF?

The symptoms of CF can vary in type and severity. Many people with CF produce a thick, sticky mucus in their bodies. This mucus builds

up and clogs the lungs, which makes it hard to breathe and can lead to infection. Mucus buildup also can affect the digestive organs,

making it hard for the body to break down food and absorb nutrients. Most males with CF are sterile and cannot have children.

Is treatment available for CF?

New drugs and treatments have improved the outlook for people with CF, but there is no cure. The disease gets worse the longer a person

has it. To treat lung problems, children with CF need to have physical therapy for about a half hour every day. This therapy helps clear

mucus from the lungs. The therapy can be done by parents or other family members.

What are risk factors for CF?

The risk of being a CF carrier is increased in families with a history of CF. The risk also is higher in certain races and ethnic groups. It

occurs more often in non-Hispanic white people than in other racial groups. But as our population has become more diverse, it is harder

to assign a person to just one ethnicity. For this reason, the American College of Obstetricians and Gynecologists recommends

offering carrier screening to all women who are thinking about becoming pregnant or are currently pregnant.

What is carrier screening?

Carrier screening uses a sample of blood, saliva, or tissue from the inside of the cheek. Carrier testing is voluntary. You can choose to

have carrier screening or not to have it. Currently, there are several approaches to carrier screening:

- Testing based on your ethnicity if your ethnic group is known to be at higher risk (ethnic-based screening)
- Testing for many disorders at once (expanded carrier screening)
- Testing for just a few specific disorders

When should I have carrier screening?

Carrier screening can be done before pregnancy or during pregnancy. If you have carrier screening before you become pregnant and both

you and your partner are carrier